



Jessica Schaaf

Postdoctoral researcher, science
communicator, and teacher

PROFILE

A postdoctoral researcher interested in uncovering the underlying mechanisms of cognitive functions like learning and decision-making, and linking these mechanisms to brain function and development. As my work is quite fundamental, I think it is especially important (and rewarding) to make sure I communicate findings in an understandable manner to a broader audience than fellow academics.

SKILLS

Open · flexible · ambitious · up for a challenge · confident speaker · good listener · collaborative · precise · attentive to details

CONTACT

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 [https://jessicaschaaf.github.io/
jessicaschaaf/](https://jessicaschaaf.github.io/jessicaschaaf/)

WORK EXPERIENCE

MAR 2023 – CURRENT

POSTDOCTORAL RESEARCHER, DONDERS INSTITUTE

Modelling of cognitive development, from exploratory behavior to working memory and intelligence

Selected publications:

- **Schaaf, J.V.**, Sørensen, Ø., McCormick, E.M., Aristodemou, M., & Kievit, R.A. (under review). Uncovering asymmetric temporal dynamics using threshold dynamics parameters. Preprint available at <https://osf.io/3b5ra>.
- **Schaaf, J.V.***, Miletić, S.*, Van Duijvenvoorde, A.C.K., & Huizenga, H.M. (2025). Interpretation of individual differences in computational neuroscience using a latent input approach, *Development Cognitive Neuroscience*, 72, 101512. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.dcn.2025.101512>.

JUL 2018 – FEB 2023 (DOCTORATE OBTAINED IN NOV 2023)

PHD CANDIDATE, UNIVERSITY OF AMSTERDAM

Setting up experimental studies, testing adolescents and adults, and modelling (the development of) feedback-based learning strategies

Selected publications:

- **Schaaf, J.V.**, Dekkers, L.M.S., Kevenaar, S.T., Seijdel, N., Weeda, W.D., Jansen, B.R.J., Visser, I., & Huizenga, H.M. (under review). First things first? Decision strategies in a consecutive context. Preprint available at <https://osf.io/cywfd>.
- **Schaaf, J.V.***, Johansson, A.*, Visser, I., & Huizenga, H.M. (2024). What's in a name: The role of verbalization in reinforcement learning. *Psychonomic Bulletin & Review*.
- Jepma, M.*, **Schaaf, J.V.***, Visser, I., & Huizenga, H. M. (2022). Impaired learning to dissociate advantageous and disadvantageous risky choices in adolescents. *Scientific Reports*, 12, 6490. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-022-10100-7>.

* Shared first authorship

SCIENCE COMMUNICATION

- **Participated in the Hoe?Zo! Show** (2020/2021, <https://hoezoshow.nl/>, also as part of **Het Weekend van de Wetenschap**), a science theater show for 9- to 10-year-olds in which I answered burning questions of over 500 children in a creative and age-appropriate manner. → for an interview by Karen Kraal see <https://www.uva.nl/shared-content/faculteiten/nl/faculteit-der-maatschappij-en-gedragswetenschappen/nieuws/2022/11/met-een-badeend-uitleggen-wat-een-ster-is.html>
- **Created educational videos and gave lectures for elementary-school children.** As part of three teaching packages (<https://www.codecstudie.nl/klas.html>), I co-created fun videos on being a scientist (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SedlvWsgGul>), on senses (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=w_3EK5WlvC8) and on memory (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kZ54oAeC9Z8>).
- **Wrote an article for clinicians** on giftedness in adults with Pleun van Vliet, published in trade journal *De Psycholoog* (2023): Gek? Of gewoon slim? Hoogbegaafdheid is niet 'meer van hetzelfde'. <https://www.tijdschriftdepsycholoog.nl/wetenschap/gek-of-gewoon-slim/> → for an interview by Tirza Lont from Folia see <https://www.folia.nl/actueel/155940/hoogbegaafd-op-de-universiteit-het-niveaus-voor-mij-te-laag>
- **Wrote blogposts on science communication** (January 2024; <https://lifespandynamics.com/posts/2024-01-02-scicom/>) **and on cognitive fluctuations** (October 2024; <https://lifespandynamics.com/posts/2024-10-31-Elections/>)

AWARD AND GRANTS

NWO SGW Open Competition L 2023 (€800.000). “How intentions and outcomes shape adolescents’ climate friendly choice: A reinforcement learning approach”. Awarded to Hilde Huizenga, **Jessica Schaaf**, Lucas Molleman, Wouter van den Bos, Cameron Brick, and Peter Verkoeijen.

CERES catalyst fund 2023 (\$50.000). “Putting the individual first: Capturing individual differences in feedback processing during educational tasks”. Awarded to Rogier Kievit, **Jessica Schaaf**, Michael Aristodemou, Amy Orben, Abe Hofman, and Monica Tentori.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Talks and workshops:

- Talk on cognitive modeling as part of workshop at CogSci 2024
- Symposium on Dynamic Structural Equation Modeling at MathPsych 2024
- Talk on adolescent risk-taking at VNOP 2022 and 2021

Posters at RLDM 2025, the Belgium-Dutch network for ESM Research meeting 2024, NVP 2023, 2022, 2019, Development Matters 2022, FLUX 2022.